

Buddhist Cosmology

THAC-DUC

In the time of the Buddha, the question of the first principle of all things held a very important place in the intellectual life of India. The Brahmajāla Sutta records as many as sixty-two different explanations offered by the Indian philosophical schools of that age. Broadly speaking, we can see three principal tendencies:

1. The tendency of fatalism (*Pubba-kata-hetu*)

The schools belonging to this tendency held that the whole natural world and the human world are arranged by predestination. Everything proceeds according to fixed natural laws already laid down. The value of human effort and material means is not acknowledged here.

2. The tendency of theism, or divine will (*Issara-nimmāna-hetu*)

The schools belonging to this tendency held that all things exist through the will of a divine being. This divine being is Brahṃā, and the center of the schools of this tendency is Brahmanism.

3. The tendency of chance (*Ahetu-apaccaya*)

The schools belonging to this tendency did not admit the principle of causation. All phenomena arise and continue by chance, without following any law or principle at all.

The first and second tendencies assign all responsibility to a supernatural power. Personal responsibility therefore does not become a real question; blessing and misfortune alike are things that human beings cannot determine. Good and evil actions on the part of human beings are not regarded as the motive force behind success or failure, growth or decline.

The third tendency also cannot establish any basis for personal moral responsibility. If everything is mere chance, then good is also chance, evil is also chance, fortune and misfortune are also chance; there is nothing that can serve as a standard for human conduct. Because of this, human beings cannot gradually advance toward truth, beauty, and goodness. On the contrary, they may very easily slide down the slope of wrongdoing and corruption.

From the point of view of theory, the doctrines belonging to these tendencies all have many shortcomings. From the point of view of human life, the consequences they bring are dark and discouraging. None of them can give a person peace of mind or a secure ground for life, nor do they affirm the necessary and already present capacities of the human being.